



Nimish Chandiramani
readersletters@thinkdigit.com

If you haven't spent as much time obsessing about sound as you have in the pursuit of the best HD (or not) picture in the last few years, you are forgiven.

For whatever reason, the sound technology we've come in contact with reached the level of "good enough" some years ago, and that's where we've stopped. Case in point: performances.

The concept of surround sound and multiple-channel audio has been...well...surrounding us since the 1940s, with Disney's *Fantasia*. And now we have the technology, so here we are. And this is the story with rock concerts too. We've been up close and personal with the sound setups at our share of performances, and for all their sophistication, they really just boil down to "put speakers in room, and turn up the volume".

But a few years ago — somewhere near Mark Knopfler's performance in Mumbai — in a casual

GET UP AND LISTEN

**Spoiler Warning:
the future of sound
technology has been
here all along**

conversation, someone brought up this crazy idea: instead of using ten big speakers and hoping that they're loud enough to cover the entire auditorium, why not just use a hundred smaller speakers all around the auditorium? This way, you don't wake the neighbours, and you give everyone — even the cheapskates in the back — a better overall experience. Win-win. It's highly possible that this someone threw the idea at the scientists at the Fraunhofer Institute, because at CeBIT 2007, we saw it in action.

IOSONO

In its physical form, Fraunhofer's IOSONO technology is exactly what we just described: a continuous band of small speakers running along all four walls. The result, however, is the most immersive experience we've ever had, including all the expensive tech we've been around in these offices. Also — and this is more significant than one would think — we could walk up